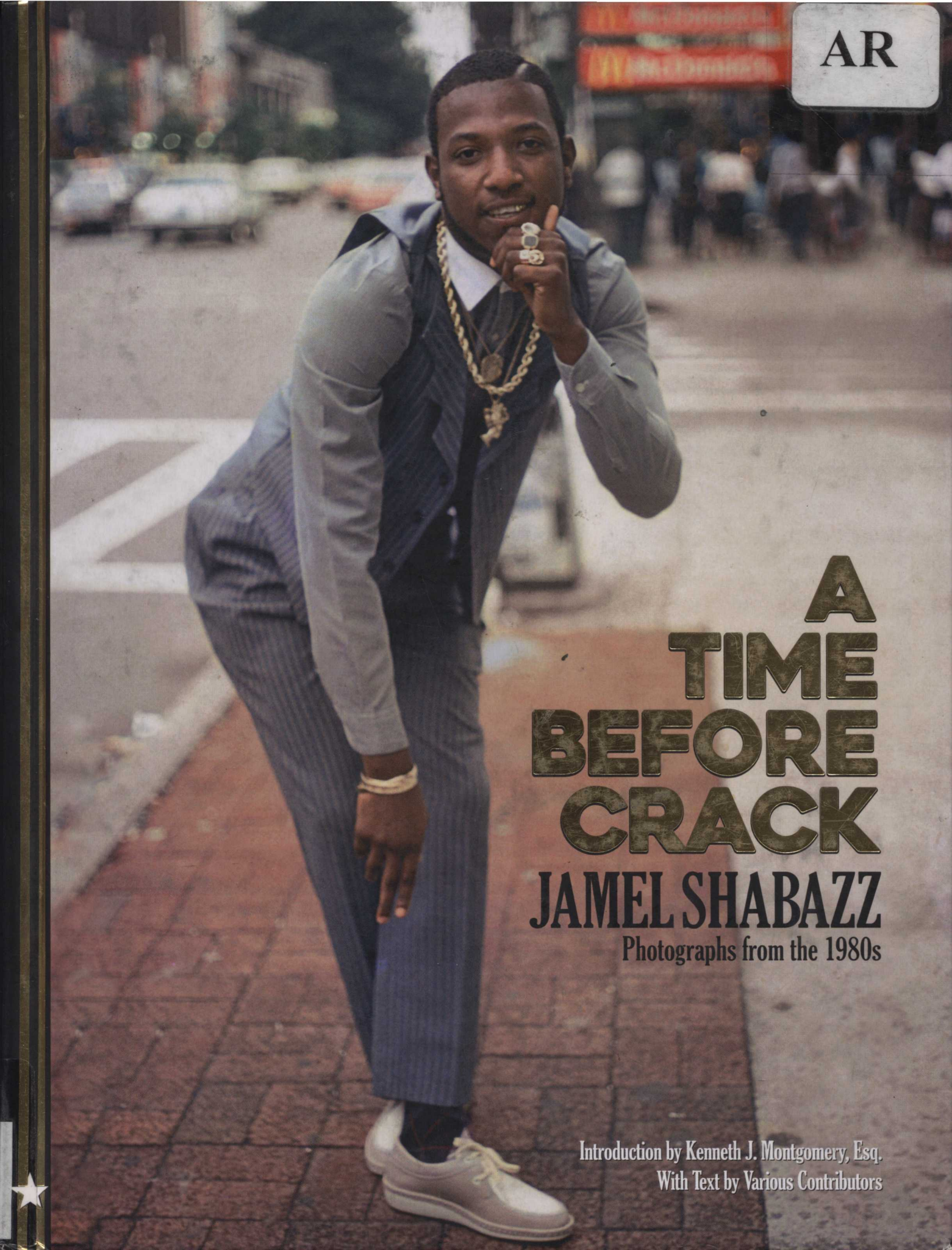




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**A
TIME
BEFORE
CRACK**
JAMEL SHABAZZ

Photographs from the 1980s

Introduction by Kenneth J. Montgomery, Esq.
With Text by Various Contributors



MOTHERS DAY
CARIBBEAN ALL STAR FESTIVAL

Liberation Day • 1982 • U.N. Official Year Against Apartheid

REAGANISM: BLACK GENOCIDE

ALL A Black Panther Party, WE WANT PROTEST, CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE AND
WE WILL STRIKE FOR BLACK LIBERTY
We will not be silent for the sake of the white man's money



...course but to take our struggle to the world's people
to the UNITED NATIONS MAY 22nd.
129th St. & 2nd Ave. March 1 pm to UN Plaza

for ALO
New York, N.Y. 10032
800 8050





INTRODUCTION

By Kenneth J. Montgomery, Esq.

The images captured by Jamel Shabazz in *A Time Before Crack* are part of a larger story and narrative regarding the Black experience in America. It exhibits the strength and expression of a people constantly in a hostile environment in America, facing a predatory and hostile enemy.

White supremacy and its advocates are focused on making sure Black people and Black consciousness remain socially, politically, and economically alienated, while at the same time seeking to be entertained and profitable from Black pain and dysfunction. Slavery and the legacy of Jim Crow along with The Great Migration and de facto segregation and other toxic racist policies and ideas prior to the 1970s would set the landscape for Black residents in New York City for years to come.

Racist social and civil engineer Robert Moses literally architected some of New York's most important highways and neighborhoods with the intent of confining Black and Hispanics in New York to the least economically viable areas in the city. Areas where corrupt landlords and realtors, along with the support of a racist real estate and banking system, would cause further urban decay and divestment from Black and Hispanic communities. They were able to accomplish this with the use of illegal and toxic financial instruments used and created by the financial industry. These financial schemes were used to destabilize Black and Hispanic communities without any oversight or accountability from the government. Landlords and business owners would set buildings on fire to collect insurance, making our communities look like a bomb was dropped in the neighborhoods: as kids, abandoned buildings and vacant lots were our playground. The government sat by as our communities fell into a state of decay that we are still suffering from, however, gentrification has made us forget the survivors of that decay and the conditions they survived. To deal with the decay and destabilization created by its own racist and discriminatory local and federal laws, America militarized the police in our communities.

During the 1970s, New York was still in the middle of a heroin pandemic and on the brink of financial collapse and bankruptcy. The federal government decided to cut funding to New York City and let it fail. In response, local New York City officials cut social funding and initiated austerity programs that would further gut social services in the city. The cuts to health and educational programs would have a disparate effect on Black and Hispanic communities, as white people took advantage of the benefits of racism and their white privilege and moved to suburbia during white flight. Many white people at the time were committed to racism and devoted to keeping Black people from living meaningful and purposeful lives. In 1975, the first year that Jamel would begin his important journey of archiving and documenting our history, *The Bill Moyers Journal* released "Rosedale the Way It Is," a series documenting the racial harassment and violence sustained by young Black children in Rosedale, Queens. The series highlighted that although Black people built the country and migrated to the north to flee violence and terror, in hopes of opportunity, the north still operated under the same colonial principles as the south.

In the prior decade, Black people in America would witness some of our most courageous Black leaders be assassinated, jailed as political prisoners, and killed by the government and police. Our organizations seeking Black self-determinism and Black nationalism were destroyed and toppled by government-sponsored law enforcement initiatives like COINTELPRO. Years prior to Jamel's journey, people like Harry Anslinger (the head of the federal Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA)) and J. Edgar Hoover (the head of the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI)), decided that Black men were the scourge of America, and America's biggest domestic threat were Black males 15 to 35 years of age. The plan for both our physical and social death had long been in place. Our communities were destabilized and were a house of cards waiting for any strong wind to blow it away. The destabilization of Black communities in cities like New York, (where Black southerners and Black people from the Caribbean had migrated), had already been completed decades prior. Crack was the strong wind that would eventually envelope, destroy, and further destabilize our communities.

Despite being in the crosshairs of white supremacy, Black people have become adept at surviving terror through our grit, intelligence, and creativity. Consistent with our history in this country, and prior to crack, we remained defiant and resilient in the face of adversity. On the heels of the Civil Rights Movement being dismantled, Black intellect and consciousness was still on edge and still percolating. In 1975, the year Jamel would begin his important journey, Elijah Muhammad would die and Arthur Ashe would become the first Black man to win Wimbledon. Two years later New York City would suffer a Blackout that would cause even more decay and birth more bad ideas from city officials; ideas that never were intended to remove poverty or crime, but only intended to manage them. Managing poverty and crime maintains the status quo for white supremacy; removing poverty and addressing the risk factors that cause crime actually dismantles white supremacy and disrupts the status quo—making the reasons we are still dealing with the problems of the past quite clear.

Jamel's photographs provide context to what happened in the past, as well as a doorway into what the future will look like. Jamel's visual storytelling would use the entire New York City as his landscape to tell the story and true narrative of what happened (and what is still happening) to us.

Jamel's images capture the hope, pain, strength, defiance, creativity, and intellect of a generation of people full of hope and promise, but no safe place to evolve and pursue that hope and promise in the face of a constantly active enemy. So many of the subjects, along with their families and friends, would eventually be corrupted and destroyed by crack. Best friends would kill each other and sell crack to each other's mothers for sexual favors. Neighborhood values and life-long bonds would be eternally broken over young men and women attempting to escape the trappings of poverty by selling crack. The phenomenon would become so enormous that we now live in a world where celebrities and media darlings who sold crack have become millionaires and moguls by selling entertainingly tall tales and stories of crack dealings and the dysfunction and violence that naturally came with it; doing so as entertainment and a way of life and viable option for another future generation of young Black people. The success of those people and the euphoria of the entertainment just might make you forget the millions who have died from addiction and violence, or the hundreds of thousands of incarcerated men from our community, or the millions of families and lives deferred as a result of crack. Crack from a cultural standpoint disarmed us and caused a crisis of values in ourselves and our communities. We used it as a vehicle into whiteness. Symbolically, it highlighted what we were willing to do to get a piece of the American dream.

The violence and dysfunction would eventually strip a generation of people like myself and so many others of our innocence and simultaneously gut the community of our most valuable resource: THE PEOPLE. It destroyed the family unit and compromised our value system to such a high degree that it distracted us from our enemy and corrupted our lens and ability to discern danger, along with causing us to forget our rich past. Jamel tells the untold story of a generation that would eventually become corrupted and commodified in America's colonial democracy and its racist economic system. Our generation would eventually provide the blueprint and scenery for corporate America and a few Black people to make trillions off of our beauty and, unfortunately, the pain and dysfunction caused by crack. Crack becomes a very valuable tool for white supremacy. Jamel's images highlight our creativity and help explain how we provide the content and context to the American experience. *A Time Before Crack* provides context and nuance to the social, political and economic history of this country, and also emphasize how important we are to the economic vitality of America—whether it's the fashion and entertainment industry copying our style and culture, or the prison industry complex and the government working hand in hand to continue to capitalize off of our social, political, and economic alienation.

A Time Before Crack is an important archive to be studied; it is the story of Black people and marginalized people, and details our journey before we became comfortably complacent and complicit in this American spectacle. These archives provide food for thought and a roadmap for future generations to reflect on what really happened to us before and after crack. And perhaps it will provide us with the wisdom to define, preserve, and protect our culture, and to control our narrative. ★









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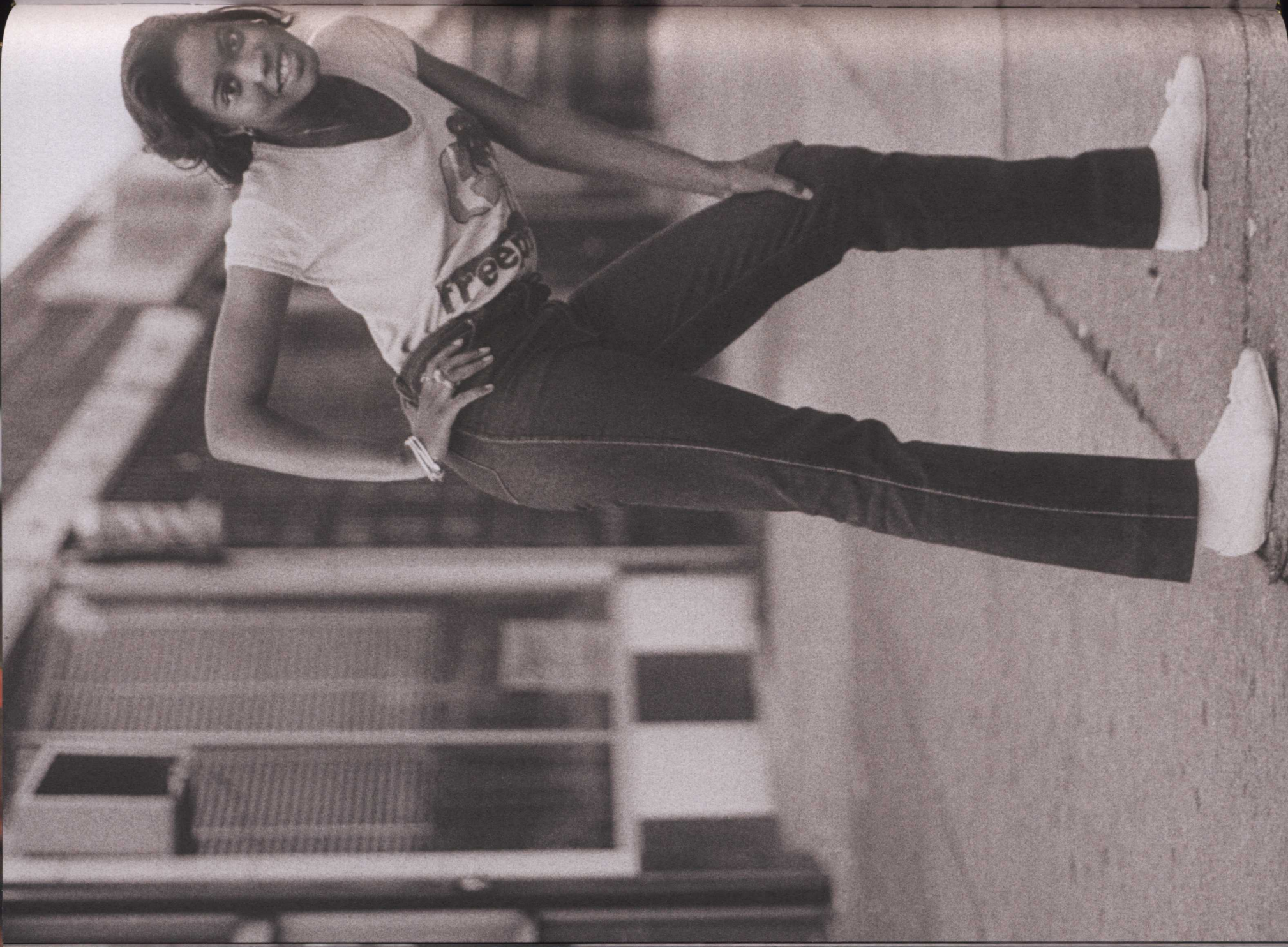
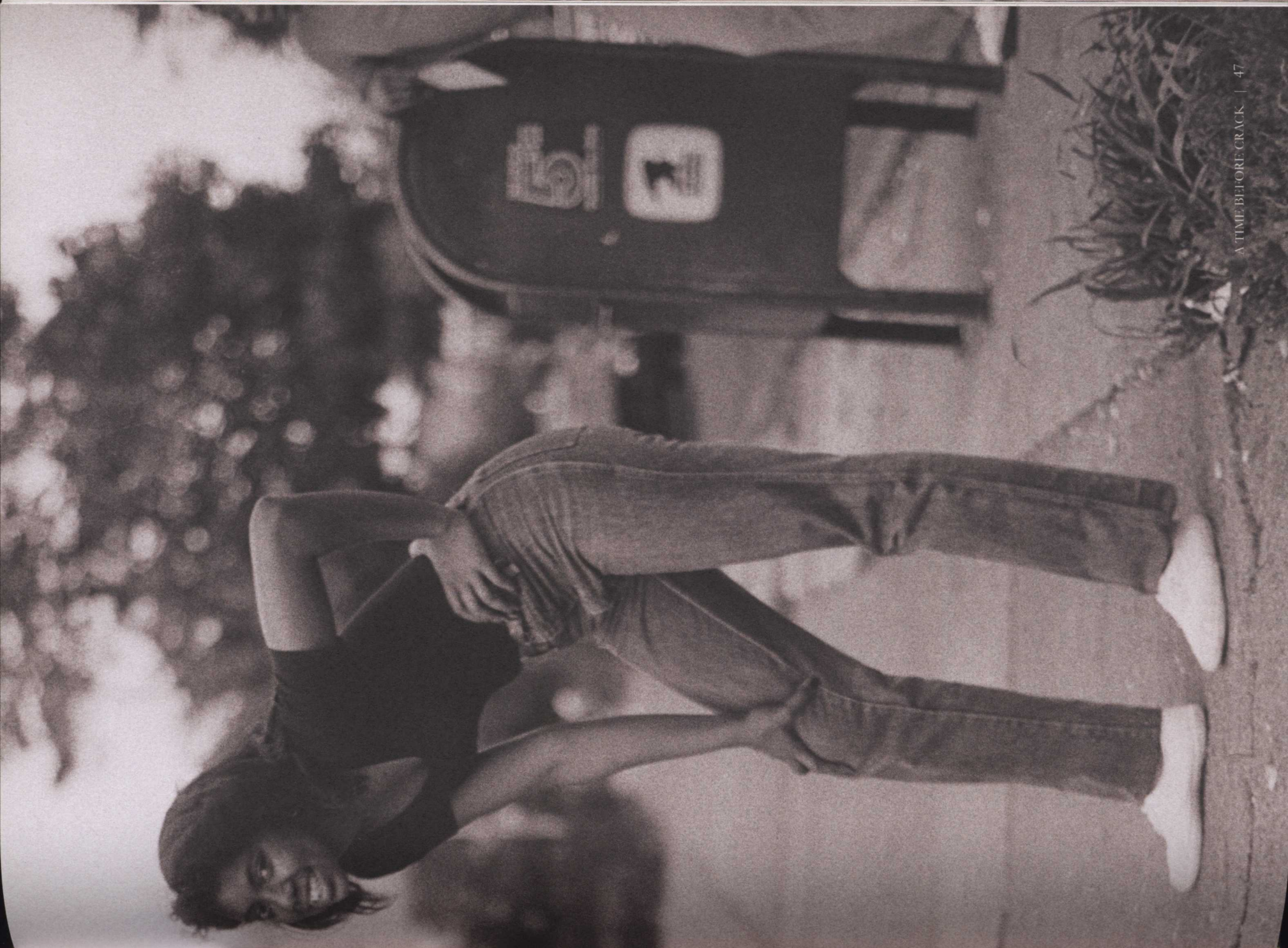
LIFE BEFORE CRACK IN RED HOOK

By Tiffany Bates-Johnson

Growing up in Red Hook Projects in the '60s and '70s was beautiful before Crack hit the community.

Red Hook was a village that raised children. Red Hook was a community that became a big family. Red Hook was full of beautiful people of different races. Women walked with dignity and men were gentlemen with morals and respect. Children were respectful to the elders, and if they were out of line, the adults were able to discipline them and take them to their parents to get disciplined again. I remember there being a time when we were able to keep our apartment doors unlocked, and your neighbor, who more than likely became a friend, was able to walk right into your apartment, and everything would be okay. Red Hook was a community of queens and kings raising beautiful children. Kids were able to play outside safely without a care in the world. I remember smelling the aromas of different dishes of food being cooked throughout the building that I lived in. The hallways were clean as well as the elevators. There was a feeling of love and unity, and years later (in the 1980s to be exact)...a horrible monster came into the community. **CRACK!**

CRACK became an ugly monster in my neighborhood. That drug literally changed beautiful men and women into **zombies!** It was like something out of a horror movie. Working-class people, both young and old, began to compromise their dignity for **CRACK**. Drug dealers who were selling this poison lost respect for anyone who fell victim to this drug. Their only concern was to make money. Children were left to fend for themselves, due to their parents becoming addicted to **CRACK**. I began to see the village, the community, the neighborhood of Red Hook decay. I started losing friends to **Crack**. People were losing their jobs. Children were being removed from their homes because their parents were becoming unfit to raise them. The sad thing was it seemed as if no one cared; no one said anything. People became afraid because it wasn't safe anymore. The drug dealers, young and old, started claiming blocks and turfs, and because of that shootings and wars started happening in this place that was once full of love. Somewhere down the line the word neighbor was removed from neighborhood and Red Hook became **HOOD**. From the 1980s up until now, in 2022, I have been praying for the neighbor to be put back in front of the word hood. We need our **NEIGHBORHOOD** back desperately! We need the love back in our communities! We need to uplift the children of the world today because they are now products of the **CRACK** era. They are lost in the wilderness and are having babies that are being raised without morals and dignity. It is up to us to take back our communities and save the babies! Let's put back the word neighbor in front of hood to make it a **NEIGHBORHOOD** once again. ★

















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Deeply unpretentious and undistracted by trendy new aesthetics or technologies. Mr. Shabazz is the best

Once upon a time before crack, inner-city communities were blighted by poverty and unemployment—but not by the drug wars that tore families apart, destroying lives with needless violence and mindless addiction. Once upon a time before crack, pride and style were as inseparable as a beatbox and mixtape, or as a pair of shoes and matching purse. Once upon a time before crack, Jamel Shabazz was on the scene, working the streets of New York City, capturing the faces and places of an era that have long since disappeared.

Best known as hip-hop's finest fashion photographer for his blockbuster best-selling monograph, *Back in the Days* (powerHouse Books, 2001), Shabazz revisited his archive and unearthed an exceptional collection of never-before-published documentary photographs collected for his third powerHouse Books release, *A Time Before Crack*. A visual diary of the streets of New York City from the mid-1970s to the mid-1980s, Shabazz's distinctive photographs reveal the families, the poses, and the players who made this age extraordinary.

“Jamel Shabazz is not just a documenter, but an artist—somebody who has a clear vision. not